GLOUCESTER
ZAKAT FUND
CHARITY FOR LOCAL RESIDENTS

SOCIAL MEDIA POLICY

Document Information	
Policy Name	Social Media Policy
Version	1.0
Policy Owner	Board of Trustees
Approved by	Board of Trustees
Date Approved	01/02/2026
Next Review Date	01/02/2028
Related Policies	Data Protection Policy, Safeguarding Policy, Complaints Policy, Counter Extremism Policy

1. Introduction

Gloucester Zakat Charity ("the Charity") is a Charitable Incorporated Organisation established to prevent and relieve poverty and financial hardship in Gloucestershire and the wider United Kingdom, with a particular focus on members of the Muslim community. The Charity collects and distributes Zakat (obligatory Islamic almsgiving) and Sadaqah (voluntary charity) to eligible beneficiaries.

Social media provides valuable opportunities for the Charity to communicate with supporters, raise awareness of its work, engage with beneficiaries and partners, and fundraise. However, the use of social media also carries risks, including reputational damage, legal liability, and safeguarding concerns.

This policy sets out the Charity's approach to social media, providing guidance for trustees and volunteers to ensure that social media is used responsibly and effectively.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Provide guidance on the appropriate use of social media by trustees and volunteers
- Protect the Charity's reputation
- Ensure compliance with relevant legislation
- Safeguard beneficiaries and others from harm
- Clarify how the Charity's official social media accounts are managed
- Set out expectations regarding personal social media use

3. Scope

This policy applies to all trustees and volunteers of the Charity. It covers both the use of the Charity's official social media accounts and personal social media use where it may affect the Charity.

4. What is Social Media?

For the purposes of this policy, "social media" includes websites, applications, and online platforms that enable users to create and share content or to participate in social networking. Examples include:

- Facebook and Instagram
- X (formerly Twitter)
- LinkedIn
- YouTube and TikTok
- WhatsApp and other messaging platforms
- Blogs and online forums
- Any other online platform where content can be shared publicly or with groups

5. Legal Framework

There is no single UK law governing social media, but social media use falls within a number of legal frameworks:

- **Malicious Communications Act 1988:** Makes it an offence to send communications that are indecent, grossly offensive, threatening, or contain false information intended to cause distress
- **Communications Act 2003:** Makes it an offence to send messages that are grossly offensive or of an indecent, obscene, or menacing character
- **Protection from Harassment Act 1997:** Protects individuals from harassment, including online harassment
- **Data Protection Act 2018 and UK GDPR:** Protects individuals' privacy and governs how personal data is processed
- **Copyright, Designs and Patents Act 1988:** Protects the rights of creators of original works
- **Defamation Act 2013:** Governs liability for defamatory statements
- **Online Safety Act 2023:** Imposes duties on platforms to protect users from illegal and harmful content

Social media has no national boundaries, so posts may be read in other countries with different legal frameworks. Care should be taken when posting content that could be viewed internationally.

6. Official Charity Social Media Accounts

6.1 Account Management

The Board of Trustees will designate which trustees or volunteers are authorised to post on the Charity's official social media accounts. Only authorised individuals may post content on behalf of the Charity.

Login credentials for official accounts must be kept secure and shared only with authorised individuals. Passwords should be changed when an authorised individual's role ends.

6.2 Content Guidelines

Content posted on the Charity's official accounts should:

- Be accurate and factual
- Be consistent with the Charity's values and charitable purposes
- Respect the privacy and dignity of beneficiaries
- Comply with data protection requirements
- Be politically neutral
- Not bring the Charity into disrepute

7. Tone of Voice

When communicating on behalf of the Charity, trustees and volunteers should:

- Be professional and courteous
- Be positive and constructive
- Respect the right of others to hold different opinions
- Speak in the first person and be authentic
- Reflect the Charity's commitment to serving the community with compassion

8. Guidelines for All Social Media Use

8.1 Privacy and Security

- Do not post personal information about others, such as home addresses, without their consent
- Never post about identifiable individuals without their consent, bearing in mind that some individuals may not be able to give informed consent
- Do not share information that could compromise security, such as the location of cash or details of when premises will be unattended
- Be mindful of data protection requirements at all times

8.2 Personal Opinions

If you are not an authorised spokesperson for the Charity, make clear that your comments, opinions, or posts are your own and do not represent the Charity's position. This statement could appear on your personal profile.

8.3 Think Before You Post

Once something is posted online, it can remain there indefinitely and may be difficult or impossible to remove. Posts may appear in search results and can be traced back to you. Consider the potential consequences before posting anything.

If you are unsure whether or how to post something, seek advice from the Chair or another trustee before posting.

8.4 Political Neutrality

The Charity must be, and be seen to be, politically neutral. The Charity may campaign for changes in law or policy that would support its charitable purposes, and may comment on policies relevant to its work, but will not support or promote any political party, candidate, or politician. Social media content must not express support for any political party.

8.5 Faith-Based Ethics

As a Muslim charity, the Charity's social media presence should reflect Islamic values. Content should not:

- Appear to support or endorse matters contrary to Islamic teachings
- Be disrespectful to any faith or religion
- Portray beneficiaries in a way that could cause embarrassment, offence, or alarm
- Compromise the dignity of those the Charity serves

8.6 Copyright

Respect copyright, fair use, and other intellectual property laws. If using images or other content created by others, ensure you have permission and acknowledge the source. Do not post content owned by another person or organisation without permission.

8.7 Do Not Be Offensive

Do not post anything that is offensive, discriminatory, or could bring the Charity into disrepute. This includes extremist views, sexism, racism, religious discrimination, disparaging comments about any group, or offensive imagery. Two useful tests: if you would not say it to someone's face, do not post it; and if you would not want it to be read by others who matter to you, do not write it.

8.8 Responding to Comments

When responding to comments or criticism, remain calm, courteous, and professional. Focus on the issue, not the person. If you disagree with something, offer a constructive response rather than a personal attack.

Be aware of online trolls who may try to provoke a reaction. Do not engage with abusive or provocative posts. If necessary, block the user, report them using the platform's reporting system, and if you believe a crime is being committed, report it to the police.

9. Use of Images

9.1 Consent

Always obtain permission before using images of identifiable individuals. It is particularly important to obtain consent from parents or guardians before using images of children, and to consider whether vulnerable adults can give informed consent.

Images of crowds at public events do not generally require individual consent, but images where a limited number of individuals are clearly the subject matter do require consent.

9.2 AI-Generated and Stock Images

If the Charity uses AI-generated, stock, or digitally enhanced imagery, particularly where the subject may be emotive or sensitive, care will be taken to ensure the imagery is not misleading. Where appropriate, such images will be identified through alt text, footnotes, or explanation in the accompanying content.

The Charity will not like, share, or support in comments any imagery or content that is reasonably suspected to be fake or misleading (including AI deep fakes).

10. Fundraising on Social Media

The Charity will comply with the Code of Fundraising Practice in all fundraising activity on social media. This includes ensuring that fundraising communications are honest, respectful, and do not place undue pressure on individuals to donate.

11. Politics and Campaigning

The Charity may campaign for changes in law, policy, or decisions where such change would support its charitable purposes, or to ensure that existing laws are observed.

The Charity will remain independent and politically neutral. It will not support or promote any political party, candidate, or politician. The Charity will not allow its social media to be used as a vehicle for the expression of the political views of any individual trustee or volunteer.

The Charity supports the democratic right to peaceful protest but will not encourage or condone any activity that breaks the law, causes harm, or places individuals at risk.

12. Moderation of Comments

The Charity believes in open and honest debate. Critical comments about the Charity's work will not be removed simply because the Charity disagrees with them, provided they are a genuine contribution to debate and are not offensive or unlawful.

The Charity will remove posts that:

- Are unlawful (including posts that are indecent, grossly offensive, threatening, or contain false information intended to cause distress)
- Would be considered offensive by a reasonable person
- Contain swear words or inappropriate language
- Are derogatory towards individuals or organisations
- Are irrelevant to the Charity's work or the conversation
- Promote extremism, hatred, or discrimination
- Could endanger the safety of individuals

The Charity may also block users who repeatedly post unacceptable content and may report serious matters to the relevant authorities.

13. Take-Down Process

Authority to remove posts from the Charity's social media accounts is delegated as follows:

- **Immediate take-down:** Posts that are clearly unlawful or unacceptable may be removed immediately by any authorised user of the account, with the Chair informed as soon as practicable
- **Other take-downs:** Posts that may be unacceptable should be referred to the Chair (or another trustee if the Chair is unavailable) for a decision

When removing a post:

- Take a screenshot or otherwise record the post before removal
- Record the reason for removal
- Any complaint about a take-down decision will be handled using the Charity's Complaints Policy

14. Breaches of This Policy

Breaches of this policy will be taken seriously. Depending on the nature and severity of the breach, action may include additional training, removal of social media access, removal from volunteer role, or, in serious cases, reporting to the Charity Commission or other authorities.

15. Review

This policy will be reviewed by the Board of Trustees every two years, or sooner if there are significant changes to the Charity's social media use, relevant legislation, or best practice guidance.

16. Related Guidance

Charity Commission Guidance:

- Managing online risk
- Political activity and campaigning by charities (CC9)
- Charities and social media

Other Guidance:

- ICO – Social media privacy settings
- IPO – Copyright notice: digital images, photography and the Internet
- National Cyber Security Centre – Social media: how to use it safely
- UK Safer Internet Centre
- Code of Fundraising Practice

17. Approval and Version History

Version	Date	Approved By	Changes
1.0	01/02/2026	Board of Trustees	Initial policy

18. Trustee Declaration

We, the undersigned trustees of Gloucester Zakat Charity, confirm that we have read, understood, and approved this Social Media Policy and commit to its implementation.

Name	Role	Signature	Date
Mr Abdullah Abdul Samad Patel	Chair	A. Patel	01/02/2026
Mr Kamel Boulkenafet	Trustee	K. Boulkenafet	01/02/2026
Mr Hashim Moolla	Trustee	H. Moolla	01/02/2026
Mr Farouq Ginwalla	Trustee	F. Ginwalla	01/02/2026
Ms Mariam Qureshi	Trustee	M. Qureshi	01/02/2026

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